Team Foundations - Study guide

Foundation course | Trainer: Priya Raman

About this guide

What makes a team work, and how to be the colleague everyone wants on theirs.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Understand what healthy teams have in common

- Contribute well in meetings

- Raise concerns early and kindly

What great teams share

- Psychological safety

- Clear goals and roles

- Reliable follow-through

Welcome to Team Foundations. Teams that work well tend to share three things. People feel safe to speak up, which is called psychological safety. The goals and roles are clear, so everybody knows what they are doing and why. And there is reliable follow-through, so when something is agreed, it happens. This lecture shows what each of those looks like on an ordinary day, and how any team member, not only the manager, can contribute to them. We will cover meetings, speaking up, and how to raise concerns early and kindly.

What healthy teams look like day to day

- People ask questions openly

- Disagreements are about the work

- Help is offered and accepted

In a healthy team, people ask questions without fear of looking foolish. Disagreements happen, but they stay about the work, not about people. Help is offered and accepted easily. Successes are shared and mistakes are discussed openly. None of this requires

everyone to be best friends. It requires respect, and some habits that make respect visible. You can start those habits yourself. Thanking a colleague, asking a genuine question, or admitting a mistake all make it easier for others to do the same. Teams are shaped by what each person does.

Meetings that matter

- Prepare before you arrive

- Contribute, and make space for others

- Summarise and follow up

Meetings take up a lot of time, so it is worth making them useful. Prepare before you arrive, by reading the agenda and thinking about what you can add. During the meeting, contribute, and also make space for others, especially quieter colleagues. Ask, what do you think. At the end, summarise what was decided and who will do what. After the meeting, follow up in writing. Anyone can improve a meeting this way, whether or not they are leading it. A short, clear summary is often the most valued contribution in the room.

Being a good contributor

- Be on time and present

- Give ideas, not only problems

- Build on what others say

Good contributors are reliable and constructive. Be on time and be present, without checking your phone. When you raise a problem, try to bring an idea along with it. Build on what others say, using phrases like, yes, and we could also. This keeps momentum, and shows that you are listening. Avoid dismissing ideas too quickly, since the first version of an idea is rarely the best. Over time, people come to see you as someone who makes the group better, and that is a powerful reputation in any team.

Speaking up

- Decide what you want to say

- Be specific and calm

- Raise it early

Speaking up can feel risky, but silence has costs too. Before you speak, decide the one thing you want to say. Be specific, for example, I am worried the deadline does not allow time for testing. Keep your tone calm, and focus on the issue, not on a person. Raise it early, when there is still time to change course. If you are unsure, frame it as a question, such as, have we thought about how this affects the customer. Speaking up well is a skill, and it gets easier each time you do it.

Responding when someone speaks up

- Say thank you

- Ask a question before you answer

- Show what you will do with it

The other side of speaking up is how you respond when a colleague raises a concern. Start with thank you. Ask a question to understand it before you answer, such as, can you tell me more about what you are seeing. And show what you will do with the information, even if the answer is that you need time to think. If people raise concerns and nothing happens, they stop. If something happens, even something small, they keep going. How the team responds to the first concern decides whether there is a second.

Handling disagreement kindly

- Assume good intent

- Separate the idea from the person

- Look for what you agree on first

Disagreement is healthy when handled well. Assume good intent, which means thinking the other person is trying to help, until you see otherwise. Separate the idea from the person, by saying, I see it differently, rather than, you are wrong. Look for what you agree on first, because that gives you a base to work from. Ask what would change your mind, and what would change theirs. When a disagreement cannot be resolved, agree who decides, and then support the decision. Respect in disagreement builds trust

faster than avoiding it.

Your next steps

- Add one thing to your next meeting

- Raise one small concern kindly

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, choose one thing that you will add to your next meeting, such as a summary of actions. Raise one small concern kindly, using the approach from this lecture. Complete the workbook for this course, which has a meeting checklist and a speaking up planner. Then take the final quiz. When you reach the end of the last lesson you will receive your certificate and a personal review of how you worked through the course. Teams improve one person’s habit at a time, and you can start today.

Glossary

Psychological safety: The belief that you can speak up without fear of embarrassment or punishment.

Follow-through: Doing what was agreed, by the date it was agreed.

Constructive: Helping move something forward, for example by offering an idea alongside a problem.

Good intent: The assumption that a colleague is trying to help even when you disagree.